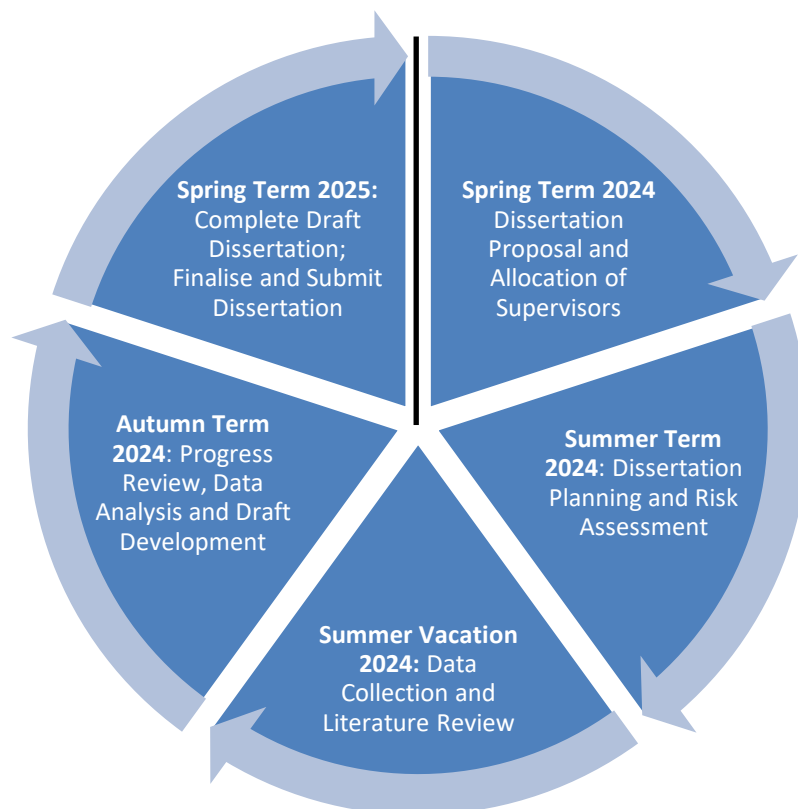




DISSERTATION HANDBOOK 2024-2025



CONTENTS

1	<u>COURSE OBJECTIVES AND CONTENTS</u>	2
2	<u>PROCEDURES</u>	10
3	<u>VERIFYING THE RESEARCH METHODS EMPLOYED</u>	15
4	<u>PRESENTATION OF THE DISSERTATION</u>	18
5	<u>SUMMARY OF IMPORTANT DATES</u>	20

1. COURSE OBJECTIVES AND CONTENTS

1.1. Aims and objectives

The aim of this course is to allow students to undertake original research in any aspect of geography, selecting the most appropriate approaches to achieve the goals of their project. Most courses teach you how to analyse a problem, with the emphasis on critical thought. The dissertation offers you an opportunity to learn how to construct a piece of research from scratch, synthesising reading and observations into a coherent exploration of a specific issue. In researching your chosen topic, you must learn to choose between the less-than-ideal alternatives that researchers always meet in practice. The course aims to foster an ability to work independently and see a complex project through from start to finish. Emphasis is put on the independence of your dissertation work, which means that you are expected to develop the project idea independently and that you are chiefly responsible for the gathering of appropriate data and its analysis.

The model for the dissertation is an academic research paper. Your dissertation should include a review of the literature and justification of the topic and approach in intellectual and practical terms. Dissertations should report findings from original fieldwork, laboratory or documentary research or analysis of source material. This may, for example, include material of a textual, numerical or visual nature. Though the dissertation should be a piece of original, geographical research it does not necessarily require the student to generate original data and may be based on original analysis of secondary data sets. In these cases, special emphasis will be put on data analysis and interpretation when evaluating the quality of the dissertation.

1.2. BSc Economics and Geography and BA/BSc Geography (International) students

Economics/Geography students do not normally take a dissertation in their final year, but exceptions may be made. If interested, please see the joint degree tutor.

BA/BSc Geography (International) (IP) students will start the dissertation process in their second year, taking GEOG0016 and the relevant methods course alongside other Geography students from their year. IP Students are strongly advised to undertake their research before they start their studies overseas or, if the research plans relate directly to the location of their IP studies, in that location. In exceptional cases, a BA/BSc (International) student may be allowed to change their dissertation plans in the autumn of their IP year (see 2.11).

1.3. Form of assessment

A dissertation will be no more than **12,000 words**. The dissertation should include an abstract, auto-critique (see 4.6) and full bibliography. The word count *excludes* the abstract, auto-critique and bibliography, as well as footnotes, tables, figures and appendices, but *includes* the references cited in the main text (see 4.3 'Word limit' for full details).

1.4. 30-credit dissertation (course GEOG0033)

The 30-credit module (GEOG0033) involves a dissertation of no more than 8,000 words. It resembles the longer dissertation insofar as it should be treated as an original research project, not an extended course paper. It can, however, be based on secondary sources, although dissertations reporting original empirical research are also welcome. In either case, the emphasis should be on the *process* of research undertaken, as an exercise in asking and answering specific research questions. You should indicate and justify the reason for the choice of topic in relation to the existing literature and consider the relevance of contemporary theoretical debates in the discipline. Research questions should be clearly specified and the approach to answering them stated and justified. You should not simply report on the problem addressed in a descriptive fashion, but rather make clear what you consider your dissertation has contributed to academic knowledge.

1.5. Registration for GEOG0037 or GEOG0033

In the spring term of the second year, all students taking GEOG0016 produce a dissertation proposal intended to prepare them for a 45-credit dissertation (GEOG0037).

In the summer term of the second year, you may opt to register for a 30-credit dissertation (GEOG0033) rather than a 45-credit dissertation. This is your choice, but the decision should follow discussions with your supervisor. If you choose to pursue a 30-credit dissertation you should inform the Geography Office via email and copy in the dissertation convenors. Any student whose dissertation proposal receives a fail mark or who does not submit a dissertation proposal before the end of the summer term (including those who have extenuating circumstances) will however be *required* to take the 30-credit dissertation (GEOG0033).

Progress will be reviewed at the beginning of the final year. This will entail the submission of a written report to be discussed in a review meeting with your supervisor (see section 2.12 below). Substantial progress normally means completing data collection, reading extensively around the topic, writing a draft literature review and undertaking preliminary stages of data analysis. It is expected that data gathering and/or analysis will be virtually complete by the time the progress report is submitted.

If your dissertation supervisor concludes that you have made insufficient progress on your dissertation, they will strongly recommend for you to register for GEOG0033 and write a 30-credit dissertation of no more than 8,000 words. You will then have to take an additional 15-credit module in your final year. You can however opt to take GEOG0033 as your own choice at any point up to the end of November in your final year. You should always discuss the decision with your supervisor, then inform the Geography Office via email and copy in the dissertation convenors.

1.6. RGS prizes

Each year, one or more dissertations from the Department are nominated for consideration for prizes offered by the Royal Geographical Society-Institute of British Geographers and its various research groups. The Department submits a copy of the dissertation and, if it is successful, notifies the student as soon as possible, generally during the following autumn or spring.

Many Research Groups post details of dissertation topics and occasionally prize-winning dissertations on the web. You may find it helpful to consult a selection of these:

- [Development Geographies Research Group](#)
- [Gender and Feminist Geographies Research Group](#)
- [Population Geography Research Group](#)
- [Quaternary Research Group:](#)
- [Social and Cultural Geography Research Group](#)
- [Urban Geography Research Group](#)

The Department has considerable success in helping students to do well in these national prizes and a list of previous winners is available on the Departmental website:

<https://www.ucl.ac.uk/geography/study/undergraduate/current-students/ucl-winners-national-undergraduate-dissertation-prizes/>

1.7. Literature to consult

Bell, J. and S. Waters (2014) *Doing your Research Project: A Guide for First-time Researchers*, 6th ed., Open University Press, Milton Keynes.

Berry, R. (2004) *The Research Project: How to Write it*, 5th ed., Routledge, London.

Blunt, A., P. Gruffudd, J. May, M. Ogborn and D. Pinder (2003) *Cultural Geography in Practice*, Arnold, London.

Clifford, N., M. Cope, T.W. Gillespie and S. French (eds) (2016) *Key Methods in Geography*, 3rd ed., Sage, London.

Dawson, C. (2007) *A Practical Guide to Research Methods* 3rd ed., How To Books, Oxford.

- Flowerdew, R. and D. Martin (eds) (2005) *Methods in Human Geography: A Guide for Students Doing a Research Project*, Longman, London.
- Gomez, B. and J.P. Jones (eds) (2010) *Research Methods in Geography: A Critical Introduction* Blackwell, Oxford.
- Hoggart, K., L. Lees and A. Davies (2002) *Researching Human Geography*, Arnold, London.
- Kitchin, R. and N.J. Tate (1999) *Conducting Research in Human Geography: Theory, Methodology and Practice*, Addison Wesley Longman, London.
- Luck, M. (1999) *Your Student Research Project*, Gower, London.
- McMillan, K. and J. Weyers (2011) *How to Write Dissertations and Project Reports* 2nd ed., Pearson, Harlow.
- O'Leary, Z. (2014) *The Essential Guide to Doing Your Research Project* 2nd ed., Sage, London.
- Parsons, T. and P.G. Knight (2015) *How to Do your Dissertation in Geography and Related Disciplines*, 3rd ed., Chapman & Hall, London.
- Peters, K. (2018) *Your Human Geography Dissertation: Designing, Doing, Delivering*, Sage, London.
- Walliman, N.S.R. (2013) *Your Undergraduate Dissertation: The Essential Guide for Success*, 2nd ed., Sage, London.

1.8. Consulting dissertations from previous years

You are strongly recommended to consult several of the dissertations from previous years in the Geography Reading Room or on the [Geography SharePoint Map Library and Reading Room link](#).

Those listed below are highly recommended.

- Afoakwa, M. (2016) 'Self, status and survival: the experience of return migration of professionals to Accra, Ghana'
- Aherne, F. (2021) 'Exploring infectious disease distribution in Greater London using quantitative spatial analysis of non-diagnostic proxy data'.
- Amrith, M. (2006) 'Indian migrant workers in Singapore'
- Atkinson, G. (2020) 'Disrupting gendered geographies of colonial knowledge and representation: a critical analysis of Beatrice Grimshaw's and Kathleen Haddon's travel writing and photography in Papua New Guinea, 1910-1914'
- Ayre, B. (2016) 'Constructing an Arctic laboratory: oil spill simulations at the hydrocarbon frontier'
- Brennan, J. (2014) 'Validation of a spectrally invariant model of canopy radiative transfer with MODIS data and its application to canopy dynamics in Amazon forests'
- Brooks, D. (2005) 'Gyms: The socio-spatial construction of gender'
- Brown, O. (2023) '“Wings”: the platform co-op reimagining the platform economy'
- Campbell, H. (2018) 'Moments of progress: An exploration of the interaction between female enterprise and patriarchal norms in Selçuk, Turkey'
- Cappai, J. (2021) 'Tapping into tech: the influence of social media on dancers and the spaces they use to dance in London'
- Chappell, L. (2013) 'An investigation into the relationship between shoreface and shoreline geomorphology along the Holderness coastline'
- Checkley, C. (2010) 'An evaluation of wave conditions and coastal features around the Isles of Scilly utilising: wave refraction modelling and coastal system mapping'
- Chan, C. (2017) 'Modelling the hydrological impacts of climate change on the Lake Eyre Basin, Australia'

- Chhaya, K. (2008) 'The second generation and transnationalism: a study of second generation Gujaratis in London'
- Chua, S. (2020) 'Women, livelihood diversification and resilience: a case study from rural Nepal'
- Clark, S. (2007) 'Modelling internal migration in the UK – can the gravity model help explain 'white flight' by comparing white and non-white internal migration in the UK'
- Colhoun, F. (2002) 'Jobs for the girls? Employment aspirations and labour market knowledge in the face of economic restructuring'
- Collier, P. (2002) 'How to preserve lowland heathland: an evaluation of three management techniques'
- Conroy, K. (2015) 'Vegetation dynamics during the Late Quaternary megafaunal extinctions: dung fungal spores as a proxy for megaherbivore abundance'
- Cowper, A. (2004) 'Bearing the burden: geographies of informal care'
- Davies-Lewis, M. (2022) 'Exploring the "peculiarity" of the Welsh: paupers, punishment, and popular protest in rural west Wales during the 19th century'
- Deng, Y. (2022) 'A tephropalaeoecology study investigating volcanic eruptions and tephra depositions' impacts on a lacustrine ecosystem in Northeast China, using diatoms as environmental indicators'
- Dhillon, K. (2010) 'Help or hindrance? The effects of philanthropic social housing near St Pancras / King's Cross on the Victorian working classes'
- Donnelly, L. (2017) 'Interpreting the revitalisation of the Los Angeles River through the lens of urban ecological citizenship'
- Du, E. (2022) 'A 19,000-year lacustrine Oxygen and Carbon Isotope record of hydroclimate variations on the Central Tibetan Plateau'
- Edden, K (2008) 'Assessment of changing flood risk in East Anglia'
- Eftychiou, A. (2023) 'Investigating the impact of the 2009 Mt Redoubt eruption on the geomorphology and dynamics of Drift River, Cook Inlet, Alaska'
- Elsam, K. (2016) 'An investigation into the factors controlling the extent of the Hadley Cell using past and future model simulations'
- Evans, L. (2011) 'Examining the impact of the zebra mussel *Dreissena polymorpha* (Pallas 1771) on Benthic macroinvertebrate community composition at stoney littoral sites in upper and lower Lough Erne, Northern Ireland'
- Forder, W. (2010) 'An investigation into the environmental contamination history preserved within the classic sediments of Bagshawe Cavern, Peak District, Derbyshire, UK'
- Foster, T. (2010) 'Modelling the hydrological effects of stream restoration at Sinderland Brook, Manchester, using HEC-RAS'
- Gardener, E (2008) 'Impacts of exotic species on distribution and abundance of native flora species at Pagham harbour'
- Gates, A. (2004) 'Assessing the generality of J.L Stein's findings for Hampstead: examining the social reception and diffusion of the telephone in Camden Town, 1890-1911'
- Goh, C. (2013) "'Do you remember...?'" Exploring memory blogging in Singapore as mnemonic resistance'
- Goldring, H. (2021) 'Migration and material culture: the Guyanese living room'
- Gordon, T. (2019) 'Suffragettes in the city: exploring gendered memory through analysis of two London exhibitions commemorating the British women's suffrage centenary.
- Grove, E. (2023) 'Lake sediment records reflect human impact on Madagascar's fire history and fire-induced geochemical change'

- Harris, A. (2014) 'Ecogeomorphological response to an anthropogenically forced reversal in the tidal regime of a saltmarsh'
- Harrison, M. (2018) 'Empowering the poor? The effects of formalising informal settlements in Dar es Salaam, Tanzania'
- Hatton, F. (2002) 'Why is there an embracing of alternative media by the anti-capitalism movement? A case study of Reclaim the Streets'
- Haynes, E (2008) 'Development of a GIS-based coastal vulnerability index for the North Norfolk coast'
- Hick, E. (2007) 'An investigation into the influence of ENSO, the PNA and the NAO on Northern Hemisphere glacial mass balance'
- Ho, J.T. (2014) 'Modelling the hydrological impacts of climate change on the Tocantins-Araguaia River Basin (Brazil)'
- Holmes, J. (2006) 'Geographies of agoraphobia'
- Hossain, K (2008) 'Disproportionate ethnic unemployment in London: the changing nature of (in) accessibility'
- Hudson, C. (2018) 'Impacts of climate change on river flows in Siberia's Lena River Basin and its implications for the Atlantic Meridional Overturning Circulation'
- Humphrey, I. (2003) 'A forest for the community? An assessment of Thames Chase Community Forest'
- Hussey, J. (2016) 'Assessing the association between industry of employment and divergent geographies of wealth in England, 1981- 2011'
- Iliev, M. (2022) 'Access to healthy assets and hazards across Warsaw'
- Iriarte Manosa, I. (2023) 'Taming the "growth machine": the case of the Encircled Garden in El Faro, Comuna 8 (Medellin, Colombia)'
- Jaitly, L. (2021) 'Tales from the 'Mutt-ropolis': exploring human-stray dog entanglements across middle-class neighbourhoods in the SDMC, New Delhi, India'
- Jenkins, W. (2011) 'The vegetation response to upland blanket bog drain blocking in the North Pennine area of outstanding natural beauty'
- Judge, R. (2007) 'Exploring Cambodian national identity: Angkor and Apsaras as "Lieux de Memoire"'
- Khan-Cheema, Y. (2020) 'Noise is subjective? Exploring residents' lived experiences of aircraft noise around London's Heathrow Airport'
- Kim, P. (2022) 'Frontier politics: Colonial ecologies, masculinity, and power in Montana'
- Knowles-Smith, A. (2017) 'Refugees and theatre: an exploration of the basis of self-representation'
- Lai, T. (2023) 'Detaching from Chinatown: a study of shifting spaces for Hong Kong migrant socialisation'
- Lam, M. (2023) 'Exploring the causal impact of mobile/pop-up vaccination units on Covid-19 uptake in South-West London'
- Lee, D. (2015) 'Ageing-environment relationships: public neighbourhood spaces in Singapore as a site of phenomenological construction'
- Lee, G. (2020) 'Stitching together: a qualitative study of craft groups in Belfast'
- Lees, E. (2021) 'The hydrological impacts of climate change on the Purus River Basin: a coupled MIKE SHE / MIKE 11 model'
- Luikham, S. (2006) 'Primary education in Ghana'
- Luscombe, C. (2011) 'A geographical study of John Wyndham and the not-so-cosy catastrophe'
- Mallett, R. (2009) "'It's like one leg is in the village, one leg is here": transition, connection and (uncertain?) aspirations among urban internally displaced people in Kampala, Uganda'

- Mallinson, H. (2014) 'Glacial isostatic readjustment of the British Isles: a study of coastal response in Western Scotland and Southern Wales'
- Malyon, C. (2005) 'Landscapes of the mind: The influence of the human life cycle on landscape preferences'
- Mavrogeni, M. (2022) 'A quantitative analysis of the COVID-19 effects on the London's Santander bike-sharing system usage patterns'
- Menon, A. (2023) 'Analysing the impact of proposed future climate scenarios on river discharge in the Upper Paraguay River Basin using hydrological modelling'
- Mileham, L. (2004) 'An investigation into the rate, causes and extent of glacial retreat on the Speke and Elena Glaciers on the Rwenzori mountains, Western Uganda'
- Neema, B. (2021) 'Comparing pond creation and restoration for biodiversity conservation in a British agricultural landscape'
- Ohrn, N. (2010) 'Women entrepreneurship and subjectivity in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia'
- Pal, A. (2004) 'Climate variability in North East Africa'
- Parry, H. (2022) 'Projections of thermally induced coral bleaching across Caribbean reefs, using a marine heatwave algorithm'
- Penman, G. (2011) 'An investigation into the interpretative flexibility of the bendy bus and its new technologies'
- Penny, J. (2009) 'Skate and Destroy?'
- Pitcher, L. (2004) 'It's bringing it all back: exploring (re)presentation and epiphany in Gap Year material culture'
- Rahemtulla, H. (2003) 'To assess the anatomy and hydrodynamic efficiency and effectiveness of Slimbridge's urban constructed wetland in the treatment of secondary waste water'
- Ren, J. (2020) 'Industrial era contamination of a remote Scottish peat bog: a palaeo-approach'
- Roberts, C. (2017) 'A multiproxy study investigating ecological response to acidification in Easedale Tarn, English Lake District, since the early 19th century'
- Robertson, H. (2019) 'Mapping elections: a quantitative analysis of cartographic visualisation techniques'
- Rochester, R. (2005) 'Modelling Hydrological Impacts of Climate Change on the Lena River, Siberia'
- Rutherford, T. (2008) 'Questioning the country childhood idyll: parenting and children's safety in three Kentish villages'
- Sherratt, K. (2015) 'Exploring the impact of rural financial insecurity on access to sanitation: a multi-dimensional approach in Karnataka, India'
- Siggery, B. (2016) 'Tracking terrestrialisation: a palaeoecological approach to assessing the restoration and management of two ponds'
- Siu, C.L. (2022) 'How symbolic capital matters: international student mobilities from Hong Kong to the UK'
- Soni, R. (2011) 'Urban regeneration and the effect on small established businesses: the case of Eastside'
- Street, S. (2022) 'Navigating the maelstrom: the conjunctural geographies of Nigerian online freelancers'
- Studholme, J. (2014) 'Determining the extratropical transition of tropical cyclones'
- Tan, J. (2022) '"I love being old. My future is now." Investigating embodied and state narratives of successful ageing'
- Taylor, L. (2016) 'The male gaze of colonial cartography: a feminist analysis of maps of Africa from the Royal Geographical Society archive, 1851-1891'

- Tetteh-Wright, T. (2019) 'Revealing the variations in Eurasian otter (*Lutra lutra*) diet through dietary analysis in the Stour and Colne catchments, Essex'
- Tsao, W. (2010) 'Environmental change in the NE Tibetan plateau, China in the recent past (circa 60 years): reconstructing past environments using records of river runoff in lake sediments of Lake Qinghai'
- Tsu-Lyn, T. (2009) 'The future of the past: heritage conservation and tourism promotion in Singapore's Chinatown'
- Tudge, A. (2015) 'What controls the evolution of erosional features in coastal dunes?'
- Wang, C. (2022) 'Assessing the impacts of climate change using hydrological modelling for the River Dee catchment, Northeast Scotland'
- Ward, N. (2019) 'The crash of ash: a study into the extent of ash dieback in Norfolk and the associated potential changes in woodland composition'
- Wee, W. (2016) 'The ecological value of Singapore's Rail Corridor Project'
- Wharton, J. (2018) 'Reconstructing AMOC over the past 7000 years: was the Industrial Era weakening an unprecedented event'
- Whittle, R. (2006) 'Knowledge and perception of EU'
- Wilkinson, J. (2009) 'Modelling the hydrological impacts of climate change on the Mekong River'

1.9. Ethics and research integrity

For a step-by-step guide to making an ethics application, see the relevant moodle page called "**UCL Geography Staff and Student Ethics Approval**" ([access here](#)). **The application itself is made from a link on that Moodle page.**

UCL researchers, including undergraduate students, are expected to be aware of the contents of the [UCL Statement on Research Integrity](#) and UCL's Code of Conduct for Research <https://www.ucl.ac.uk/research/integrity/ucl-code-conduct-research>. They are expected to observe in their research the principles of honesty, rigour, transparency and open communication, and care and respect – defined as follows.

- **Honesty** in all aspects of research, including in the presentation of research goals, intentions and findings; in reporting on research methods and procedures; in gathering data; in using and acknowledging the work of other researchers; in structuring and writing the dissertation; and in conveying valid interpretations and making justifiable claims based on research findings.
- **Rigour**, in line with prevailing disciplinary norms and standards: in performing research and using appropriate methods; in adhering to an agreed protocol where appropriate; in drawing interpretations and conclusions from the research; and in communicating the results.
- **Transparency and open communication** in declaring conflicts of interest; in the reporting of research data collection methods; in the analysis and interpretation of data; in making research findings widely available, which includes sharing negative results as appropriate; and in presenting the work to other researchers and to the general public.
- **Care and respect** for all participants in and subjects of research, including humans, animals, the environment and cultural objects. Those engaged with research must also show care and respect for the stewardship of research and scholarship for future generations.

Your attention is drawn to the University policy on the use of AI: <https://www.ucl.ac.uk/students/exams-and-assessments/assessment-success-guide/engaging-ai-your-education-and-assessment#examples>. Unauthorised use of AI, including failure adequately to cite it, constitutes academic misconduct at UCL and could result in disciplinary action including significant deductions of marks or more serious penalties. A document outlining the Department's AI policy can be found on the Practice of Geography Moodle Page.

You must consider the ethical dimensions of your research when writing your proposal. Both human and physical geographers must consider their relevant professional and institutional codes of ethics. Two key codes are introduced below and will be discussed in GEOG0016 The Practice of Geography module.

The [Framework for Research Ethics of the Economic and Social Research Council](#) identifies six key principles:

1. Research should be designed, reviewed and undertaken to ensure integrity, quality and transparency.
2. Research participants must normally be informed fully about the purpose, methods and intended possible uses of the research, what their participation in the research entails and what risks, if any, are involved.
3. The confidentiality of information supplied by research participants and the anonymity of respondents must be respected.
4. Research participants must take part voluntarily, free from any coercion.
5. Harm to research participants must be avoided in all instances.
6. The independence of research must be clear, and any conflicts of interest or partiality, explicit.

The guidelines and procedures of the central [UCL Research Ethics Committee](#) mean we cannot currently approve undergraduate research involving interaction with:

- a) anyone under the age of 18
- b) anyone with a learning disability or cognitive impairment
- c) anyone likely to be regarded as 'vulnerable', such as those in a 'dependent but unequal relationship', including prisoners, detainees, asylum seekers or residents in a psychiatric hospital.

If your proposed research topic might fall under one of these headings or raise questions in relation to one of the six principles listed above, consult the relevant dissertation convenor as soon as possible.

In addition, we cannot approve undergraduate research on what the UCL Ethics Committee defines as 'sensitive topics' or those falling in other 'more than minimal-risk' categories UNLESS exclusively non-sensitive, anonymous, tests, survey or interview procedures are employed in such a way as to ensure that participation will not induce undue psychological stress or anxiety in participants.

The Department also considers that it has an ethical responsibility towards students, such that dissertation research that could expose a student researcher to harm should be avoided. That harm might be of a physical nature: see section 2.8, Risk Assessment. In addition, however, no activities can be authorised that might expose the researcher to risk of investigation or possible arrest on suspicion of undertaking or inciting others to undertake criminal activities, or that involve activities undertaken without the permission of those legally entitled to prohibit certain activities in a given space. In addition, students should approach their personal tutor or supervisor, or the relevant dissertation convenor, if they have any concerns associated with their physical or mental health, so that the outcome of discussion with departmental representatives can be built into their risk assessment as appropriate.

1.10. Organised dissertation 'expeditions'

Some commercial and charitable organizations, such as Operation Wallacea and Frontier, run 'expeditions' related to conservation and other projects that may ostensibly form the basis of a dissertation. Participation in such expeditions is not an acceptable basis for a Geography dissertation, since students are expected to devise their own topics from the outset and undertake the research on their own initiative.

1.11. Academics as sources of information

You should not plan to conduct interviews with academics in UCL or other universities as a source of material for your dissertation.

1.12. Dissertation convenors

Physical geography/GIS/remote sensing dissertations: Helen Bennion h.bennion@ucl.ac.uk

Human geography dissertations: Year 2 students – Ben Page b.page@ucl.ac.uk; Year 3 & 4 students- Johanna Waters, johanna.waters@ucl.ac.uk

Social data science dissertations: Anwar Musah a.musah@ucl.ac.uk

2. PROCEDURES

2.1. Allocation of supervisors

The allocation of supervisors is decided by the dissertation convenors. However, students do get the opportunity to request individual academics who they think would be suitable for their project. We cannot guarantee that you will be allocated the supervisor you request. You are strongly advised to identify potential supervisors and discuss your interests with them early in the spring term of the second year or as early as the autumn term if you already have a vague idea. You are best advised to think about this based on the subject rather than the methodology. Your first-year academic tutor cannot normally supervise your dissertation. Some staff are on sabbatical leave each year, so you may need to name someone else. You may still consult other staff during their ASF hours throughout the dissertation process even if they are not your supervisor.

You should submit a supervision request at the bottom of your Topic Outline Form on **Friday 9th February 2024** (see Moodle for GEOG0016). Tell us which member of the teaching staff you would like to supervise your dissertation. We aim to tell you who your supervisor will be by Friday 1 March 2024.

2.2. Field/laboratory equipment and work approvals

Spring term (second year):

Students wishing to use any departmental field/laboratory equipment **must discuss this with Jamahl Holland (Laboratories and Safety Manager) before submitting their proposal**. At the end of May, supervisors will check that the fieldwork proposed is practicable, that the cost of Departmental laboratory or field consumables/equipment will not be excessive and that you will be able to undertake any laboratory analysis/fieldwork.

Summer term (second year):

Approval of a dissertation proposal does not mean that the Department guarantees to make the necessary equipment available. If it is not available, you must modify your proposal and notify the physical geography dissertations convenor of the changes agreed by **Wednesday 5 June 2024**. Furthermore, any use of laboratory space needs to be discussed with Jamahl Holland and subsequently booked by **Thursday 30 May 2024** (Wednesday 5 June if resubmitting). Students are encouraged to undertake as much laboratory work as possible before the autumn term as labs can become very busy during that term and it also prevents any difficulties with fitting in lab work around first-term lectures and course work commitments. If difficulties with lab work do arise at any time, then students should speak to their supervisor as soon as possible.

2.3. Dissertation fieldwork expenses

Fieldwork and associated expenses will have to be covered by the student undertaking the project. Please, keep this in mind when planning the research, so that costs will not become excessive.

There are the departmental Mead Fund Travelling Fellowships for travel to Northern Europe, with a deadline in late February. Look out for announcements relating to this.

One other potential source of funding is the [Royal Geographical Society](#).

You should note the various deadlines for these applications if you are interested and remember that they are all competitive so there is no guarantee of funding.

2.4. Starting work on the dissertation

Work on the dissertation should be started as soon as your second-year examinations are complete. You should work on a literature review or other preliminary data collection, as appropriate, that will be relevant to your chosen topic whether the specific proposal you submitted is approved or needs further work.

The final two weeks of the summer term, at least, should be entirely dedicated to advancing the dissertation and you should carry out information collection/field observations during the summer vacation. In all, you should expect to dedicate about six weeks of intensive work to your dissertation research, including the last two weeks of term.

2.5. Evaluation of dissertation proposal

Dissertation proposals are submitted as part of the assessment for GEOG0016. The results will be announced by **Monday 20 May 2024**.

Each proposal will be placed in one of the following categories:

- a) Approved subject to safety and equipment considerations (see below).
- b) Not approved - the proposal does not form the basis of a feasible dissertation. You must produce a new proposal before **Wednesday 5 June 2024**.

2.6. First formal supervisory meeting

Supervisors will normally arrange a meeting between **Tuesday 28** and **Wednesday 29 May 2024**. If you do not hear from them, please contact them. If your supervisor is on sabbatical, another member of staff will be asked to see you. If you are allocated different supervisors for the autumn and spring terms of your final year, you should see your autumn term supervisor in the first instance.

2.7. Contract of work to be undertaken before autumn

At the first supervisory meeting, student and supervisor should discuss what will be required for the progress report to be submitted in the autumn (see section 2.12). They should agree specific details of what work is to be undertaken and reported, and the supervisor will record that agreement briefly in an email to the student, during or after the meeting, keeping a copy of the email.

2.8. Risk assessments

Before starting work on dissertation research, it is essential that all students identify risks and complete a Risk Assessment. See <https://www.ucl.ac.uk/geography/resources/safety/fieldwork-risk-assessment-forms-and-files>. Risk Assessments should be discussed with your supervisor.

For those proposing to undertake fieldwork

Fieldwork is defined as any research activity undertaken outside your own home or off UCL campus.

EITHER: 1) If you are planning to undertake fieldwork involving surveys, interviews, focus groups, archive work or participant observation, then first complete the **Geography Generic Risk Assessment**. Please note that you should NOT simply tick all hazard/risk categories that apply but go through every control measure proposed and tick each one that applies. Any form on which *all* control measures have been ticked will not be accepted unless the research proposal does indicate that all apply.

OR: 2) If you are planning physical geography fieldwork (for lab work see below), then first complete the

Dissertation Fieldwork Risk Assessment template. You may seek help from your supervisor or Jamahl Holland, the lab manager.

OR: 3) If you are planning laboratory work you need to discuss the proposed work with your supervisor and select the appropriate Risk Assessment form from the relevant [Departmental webpages](#). A laboratory induction will also need to be arranged prior to the start date.

In all cases: on completion these forms should be agreed with the supervisor and emailed by the student to Jamahl Holland (jamahl.holland.18@ucl.ac.uk). Emailing the completed forms with a typed signature constitutes signing and agreeing - you do not need to sign them by hand.

For those proposing to undertake fieldwork abroad

If the approved proposal involves fieldwork abroad students requiring UCL Travel Insurance should contact the Departmental Office about dates, destination, type of activity and travel itinerary. If cover can be arranged, an insurance cover-note will be provided. Any insurance arranged does not cover holiday activities, only UCL business. Those using family/annual travel insurance should ensure it covers all proposed activities and locations. Proposed travel against Foreign and Commonwealth Office advice should be discussed with Jamahl Holland in the first instance.

For all students

The risk assessment should be completed by **Thursday 30 May 2024**. Students required to produce a new proposal should complete their risk assessment as above by **Wednesday 5 June 2024**.

NB: You are not authorised to undertake research, whether it is fieldwork or lab work, before you have submitted an appropriate risk assessment for the work to be undertaken and before it has been approved. The Head of Department, acting in consultation with Jamahl Holland and the dissertation convenors, has the final say on whether work on a given topic can be undertaken.

2.9. Students whose proposal is not approved

If your proposal is not approved for dissertation purposes or fails (mark for the GEOG0016 proposal < 40), you must modify it to take account of the points raised by the assessors and submit the new version to the relevant dissertation convenor by **Wednesday 5 June 2024**. We will let you know whether we believe it can lead to a successful dissertation. If we do not believe it can, you must choose how to respond. You need either to modify it immediately - before the end of term on **Friday 7 June 2024** - with the possibility of taking a 45-credit dissertation in your final year or to accept that you will be registered for a 30-credit dissertation in your final year.

2.10. Changing an approved dissertation topic

This is not allowed except in certain **exceptional** (unforeseen) circumstances. You should consult the respective **dissertations convenor as well as your supervisor** immediately should the need arise.

2.11. BA/BSc Geography (International) students

All Geography (International) degree students should provide **TWO** progress reports during their year away. The first, to be submitted by **Monday 11 November 2024**, should follow the format described in 2.12 a) and should be submitted via Turnitin. If your dissertation supervisor comes to the conclusion that you have made insufficient progress on your dissertation, you can then:

EITHER a) improve your progress substantially by the time of the second report (see below)
OR b) change your dissertation topic. If you opt for a change of topic, you must produce a new proposal, identical in format to that produced in the second year and submit it for approval to the relevant dissertation convenor by **Monday 13 January 2025**. The new proposal will be assessed by the dissertation convenor and may or may not be approved in place of the original proposal. No change of supervisor will normally be permitted. **No other changes to dissertation plans will be permitted. Any requests after this date will result in registration for a 30-credit dissertation.**

The second progress report should be a 1,500-2,000-word report on work achieved (see GEOG0068 Study Abroad Year Dissertation Report on Moodle) to be submitted via Turnitin and directly to your

supervisor by **Monday 19 May 2025**. Satisfactorily completing the Study Abroad Year Dissertation Report is necessary for progression into year 4 although it is not graded. More information will be provided by the International Tutor.

On return to UCL, you should follow the same procedures as other students moving into their final year. The relevant dates for submission of the autumn progress report (see 2.12), draft text and the dissertation itself will all be available in the 2025-2026 dissertation handbook on Moodle. If your dissertation supervisor comes to the conclusion that you have made insufficient progress on your dissertation, they will strongly recommend for you to register for GEOG0033 and write a 30-credit dissertation of no more than 8,000 words. Students will then have to take an additional 15-credit module in their final year. For the Autumn Progress Report, you may recycle relevant material from your GEOG0068 report although progress since May is expected.

During your Year Abroad, there are no specific guidelines for supervision, but it is advised that you make contact with your supervisor to ask for advice via Teams, as required, and at least once per term. Mid-November might be an appropriate time to arrange a meeting with your supervisor in Term 1 to discuss feedback on your November report. In Term 2 you might wish to arrange a meeting to discuss your progress prior to submitting your Study Abroad Year Dissertation Report in mid-May.

2.12. Approval of registration for GEOG0037

All students must provide a progress report on work achieved and plans for completion, to be submitted on Moodle by **Friday 4th October 2024 (Thursday 5th December 2024** for those on Term Abroad). It is expected that substantial progress will have been achieved on data gathering and/or data analysis, as well as reading around the topic. Students should plan to spend a considerable period of their summer vacation on their dissertation. Please note that the Autumn Progress Report is not a piece of summative assessment and extensions will not be given, except for illness in the last few days before submission, to be demonstrated by submission of a medical note to the office, for the information of the relevant convenor. Only students with relevant SORAs can have extra time.

The progress report will have two elements, both to be included in the same file:

- a) a report on work undertaken, plus plans for completion, with proposed target deadlines. This could appropriately be in the form of bullet-pointed lists or short paragraphs under appropriate sub-headings, and should not be more than two sides long;
- b) a 2,000-word academic report contributing to the dissertation. Depending on the nature of your topic this report might be primarily a detailed literature review, a preliminary account of the field / laboratory work undertaken, secondary data collected and analysis of these data, or a mixture of these elements. The exact nature of what is required will have been agreed with the supervisor in June and recorded in the work contract described in section 2.7. The report must adhere to normal academic standards (it must be written in academic style, with necessary references provided). It is anticipated that some of the content of this report could be used in your final dissertation. You may reproduce material from your GEOG0016 proposal (e.g. key elements such as the title, aims/objectives, some of the literature review and citations) without any risk of self-plagiarism. However, we would normally expect to see evidence of additional reading in your final dissertation literature review, so re-using your proposal literature review verbatim is not likely to lead to a high grade. The report should indicate how your ideas and substantive work have developed since submitting your proposal.

Supervisors will provide verbal feedback on the progress report during the first final-year tutorial meeting, plus at least 100 words written feedback in the Moodle Turnitin text box.

NB: Any student making insufficient progress with their dissertation research by the autumn will be strongly advised to register for GEOG0033, the 30-credit dissertation. This decision should be made jointly by yourself and your supervisor. You can, however, opt to register for GEOG0033 as your own choice at any point up to the end of November in your final year.

Once the decision that you register for a 30-credit dissertation has been taken, it is not possible to return to a 45-credit registration.

2.13. Supervision during final year

The final-year tutorial is based on fortnightly dissertation supervision meetings. Supervisors and students should agree a schedule of meetings at the start of each term. Supervision will include a mixture of group and individual meetings. Some tutorials may appropriately be used as 'workshops' on dissertation topics: for example, data analysis, presentations of empirical chapters, integrating literature etc. For the autumn term, we suggest dissertation supervision might focus on analysis of data and feedback on drafts of empirical chapters. The spring term could best be used to support writing introductory, methodological and concluding chapters; editing the text; and integrating the argument for the final dissertation (but please see 2.15 on not commenting on repeated drafts of the same material). The specific schedule of work and meetings will depend on the needs of individuals in each supervision group.

At the end of each supervision meeting in the final year, you should record your agreed actions with your dissertation supervisor on a dissertation supervision sheet. This is kept by the dissertation supervisor, so please ensure you take note of the agreed actions at each meeting.

It is worth noting that your dissertation supervisor is there to help you reflect on the practical and theoretical choices you face in doing your dissertation work but cannot make these decisions for you. You are encouraged to consult other relevant members of staff on dissertation matters during their ASF hours. If you experience any problems with supervision, which you cannot resolve in discussion with your supervisor, you should inform the dissertation convenors as soon as possible.

For students on their Term Abroad, there are no specific guidelines for supervision during your term abroad but it is advised that you make contact with your supervisor to ask for advice via Teams, as required. Term Abroad students must provide a progress report on work achieved and plans for completion, to be submitted on Moodle by **Thursday 5th December 2024**. It is expected that substantial progress will have been achieved on data gathering and/or data analysis, as well as reading around the topic. You might find an online meeting with your supervisor useful for getting feedback on your report.

2.14. Barring students from assessment

Attendance at dissertation supervisions and a timely response to communications from your supervisor are a formal engagement requirement for the dissertation module. In addition to the usual engagement requirements for modules, any student failing to complete either the progress report by the date noted above (section 2.12) or any further deadlines and agreed programmes of work set by their supervisor may be barred from assessment of the dissertation module. To be readmitted to the dissertation module (either a 45-credit or 30-credit dissertation) the student will be required to complete a Learning Agreement. A Learning Agreement will be drawn up by the Departmental Office in discussion with the Departmental Tutor, the dissertation convenors and the supervisor. More information on UCL's Policy and Procedures for Learning Agreements and Barring Students from Assessment can be found in the UCL Academic Handbook.

2.15. Comments on draft dissertations

You cannot submit written text to your supervisor for detailed comments after **Friday 14th February 2025 (Wednesday 12th March 2025** for Term Abroad students). If you produce draft text for your dissertation before this date you may expect detailed comments from your supervisor. Feedback may refer to both content and presentation but will be formative only - i.e. it CANNOT suggest a predicted grade for your final dissertation. If there are Extenuating Circumstances, the dissertation convenors may agree to an extension to these dates in advance. Any feedback after that date must be within a supervisory tutorial only, and only on material that has not been submitted to the supervisor in advance of the meeting.

This date is fixed across the department to encourage you to start writing significant parts of the dissertation early in the year and to ensure that the final dissertation submitted is a fair and accurate reflection of your own work. The more work you put into producing draft text early in the year, the more constructive feedback your supervisor will be able to provide. This also ensures you have time to reflect on, edit and integrate your work for the final dissertation submission. **You should agree with your supervisor a date for return of comments and feedback on dissertation drafts as part of each**

term's programme of meetings. However, detailed written feedback cannot be provided on repeated drafts of the same material. Once such feedback has been provided, you can still discuss a revised draft verbally, within a supervisory tutorial, but only on material that has not been submitted in advance.

2.16. Submission of dissertation

Deadline: MONDAY 24th MARCH 2025 (MONDAY 28th APRIL 2025 for 'Term Abroad' students).

The dissertation should be submitted electronically via Moodle Turnitin (the Moodle page for GEOG0037, whether you are registered for GEOG0037 or for GEOG0033).

It should be submitted anonymously (using your Examination Candidate Code and supervisor's name) as a Word document or PDF of up to 100 MB - see section 4.8.

3. VERIFYING THE RESEARCH METHODS EMPLOYED

To present research findings when you have not actually undertaken the research in question is cheating. Fabrication of research results constitutes an examination irregularity.

To verify the methods used you must follow the guidelines below. You should:

- keep material obtained during your research for us to inspect at any time;
- provide accurate descriptions of the methods used in your dissertation; and present supporting evidence in an appendix to your dissertation.

3.1. Keeping research material

You are responsible for being able to provide evidence of the research undertaken for the dissertation until your degree result has been confirmed by the University. This includes:

- a) all material on paper, such as:
 - all completed questionnaires
 - all transcripts of recorded material
 - photographs
 - photocopies of/notes on archive or visual material
 - all field notes or observations and research diaries
- b) recordings, however recorded/on whatever format, such as:
 - recorded interviews
 - recorded focus group discussions
- d) all electronic data files
- e) any computer programs/code written specifically for your research.

You may be required to present any or all of this material at any point as part of the normal examination process. If we ask to see it, you should not assume that we are making an allegation of irregularity. If, however, you fail to present the material in question for our inspection if asked to do so, we may present this as evidence to support an allegation of irregularity.

3.2. Information required on methods employed

Ideally, this should form part of the text (and provides a useful guide to points to cover in the methods section). If undertaking research in physical geography, you must include photographs of field sites. Including appropriate, properly captioned photographs and maps is good practice for *all* dissertations.

- a) Questionnaires

- Information on how the sampling frame was constructed (i.e. how did you know who to approach? How did you define appropriate respondents?)
- Comments on your sampling strategy and access issues
- Number of questionnaire survey respondents you approached
- Method of completion of survey: face-to-face interview (where?); completion by researcher; self-completion by respondent (how were surveys returned to you?)
- Number of completed questionnaires obtained
- Response rates, with comments on reasons for good/poor response rate
- If survey is of economic enterprises, relevant (anonymised if necessary) details of each firm (in the text, a figure or an appendix)

b) Focus groups

- Number of groups held and composition of each group (i.e. why was this an appropriate group for your research?)
- Comments on recruitment strategy and access issues
- Brief comments on the group discussions: frequency/fluency of participation etc.
- No. of participants and brief details about each one (in a figure or appendix)
- Recording and transcription procedures employed: all transcribed? If not, how were transcribed sections selected etc?

c) Interviews

- Recruitment strategy for interviewees, access issues etc.
- Details of date and location of each interview
- Recording and transcription procedures employed (not all recordings need fully transcribing). How was material to be transcribed selected?
- Brief personal profile of interviewees
- Issues covered (probably best addressed by presenting interview schedule in appendix)

d) Physical geography projects

- Information on all sampling strategies (field and laboratory based)
- Description, maps and photographs of field sites – location, characteristics etc.
- Route/approach to computer-based experiments, coding and data examination

e) All dissertations where using figures, tables etc.

- All tables, charts etc. must show the total number of respondents or samples relating to each variable analysed (N=...).
- The use of simple percentages in text will be unacceptable unless supported by information on the number of respondents or samples for each variable discussed.

3.3. Supporting evidence to be provided in appendices

Appendices should be used sparingly, but should include the following if relevant:

- One completed questionnaire for each survey undertaken
- Interview and focus group question schedules
- 3-5 pages of transcript from one focus group or interview, where transcribed
- One copy of any covering letter to survey participants including clear instructions about how the survey is to be completed and returned to you, if not on a face-to-face basis
- One copy of any covering letter to interviewees
- Letters giving permission for activities to be undertaken on private premises (e.g. a shopping mall), or seeking any other permissions required
- Fully commented code of programs written specifically to process data, indicating which parts were written by the student.
- Workspace/command history where programming environment allows this to be exported as a text file or one or more appropriate screenshots.

4. PRESENTATION OF THE DISSERTATION

4.1. Overlap with dissertation proposal (GEOG0016) or academic progress report

You may reproduce material from your GEOG0016 proposal (e.g. key elements such as the title, aims/objectives, some of the literature review and citations) without any risk of self-plagiarism. However, we would normally expect to see evidence of additional reading in your final dissertation literature review, so re-using your proposal literature review verbatim is not likely to lead to a high grade. It is entirely acceptable to use material from the autumn academic report in the dissertation.

4.2. Elements to be included (in this order)

TITLE PAGE giving a short title, your candidate code, the name of your supervisor and the year
DECLARATION OF ORIGINALITY, also stating the WORD COUNT (template available on Moodle; you should use your Examination Candidate code to complete this declaration, not your name)
ABSTRACT of no more than 300 words
ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS
LIST OF CONTENTS – do not forget to include page numbers
LIST OF TABLES if relevant
LIST OF FIGURES if relevant
LIST OF ACRONYMS if relevant (but use sparingly in the text)
MAIN TEXT. Chapters are numbered from Introduction onwards (
AUTO-CRITIQUE of not more than 500 words (not included in the word count)
APPENDICES
LIST OF REFERENCES

4.3. Word limit

12,000 words (GEOG0037) or 8,000 words (GEOG0033).

The word count should be stated on the Declaration of Originality form. The word count is for the main text. It **includes** short quotations (i.e. those *not* to be placed in a text box – below 100 words) from the literature or interviews. It also includes headings and subheadings as well as reference citations in the main text. It **excludes** the declaration of originality, title page, abstract, acknowledgements, content list, auto-critique, list of references, tables/figures with their title and captions, footnotes (if used to reference primary source material), equations with their expanded description and appendices.

Transcript extracts (not quotations from the literature) of 100-250 words, if discussed in the text, can be treated as figures and placed in a box. They should contain either one continuous extract or a series of shorter extracts all illustrating the same point. However, large numbers of text boxes can detract from the clarity and communication of an argument; you should use them sparingly. Appendices, including longer transcript extracts (above 250 words), are not counted but must be discussed in the text. Footnotes should be used extremely sparingly. Misuse of text boxes, appendices and footnotes (e.g. to avoid extending the text beyond the word limit) may adversely affect the examiners' assessment.

Your work must be well structured and effectively edited within this limit. **Marks may be deducted for work that is poorly structured, prolix or overly concise.** 'Concise' means 'brief but comprehensive'. Concise writing makes a point succinctly but clearly. Work that is overly concise makes its point so succinctly that it is only partial and clarity is lost. 'Prolix' writing is tediously prolonged, telling us more than we want to know. It is long-winded and generally meandering and repetitive. You are encouraged to edit your work carefully. Good editing reduces words, improves readability and clarifies concepts. You may find it helpful to consult William Strunk Junior's '[The elements of style](#)' (esp. III 13).

Please note that for work that exceeds the word length stated above by less than 10%, the mark will be reduced by 5 percentage points, but the penalised mark will not be reduced below the pass mark, assuming the work merited a pass; for work that exceeds a specified maximum length by 10% or more, the mark will be reduced by 10 percentage points; but the penalised mark will not be reduced below the pass mark, assuming the work merited a pass.

4.4. Abstract (300 words)

The abstract is a summary of the dissertation as a whole; it should not be used as an introduction. It should identify the main research question and the methodology adopted; describe the nature and extent of the research carried out; and briefly summarise the main findings.

4.5 Chapter numbering

An 'introduction' may also be included addressing e.g. the significance, the main aim and objectives and possibly research questions, before you approach the chapter with the literature review. Alternatively, you may wish to place the research questions after the literature review, since this serves to justify them. In either case, all chapters should be numbered consecutively i.e. Chapter 1: Introduction, and so on.

4.6 Auto-critique (500 words, not included in the word count for the dissertation)

The auto-critique should assess how far the objectives of the dissertation have been achieved. You should discuss the strengths and weaknesses of your research; and how, in hindsight, you might now go about undertaking it differently. Whilst any major unforeseen circumstances affecting the research may be mentioned, the emphasis is on reflection on your own practices and learning, not constraints (such as word length) affecting all students equally.

4.7 Presentation format

- The dissertation should be submitted **AS A WORD FILE OR PDF** of up to 100MB
- The filename **MUST** be **[THE SURNAME OF YOUR AUTUMN-TERM SUPERVISOR]underscore [YOUR EXAMINATION CANDIDATE CODE]** eg BENNION_ABCD1.docx or BENNION_ABCD1.pdf
- ILLUSTRATIONS (maps, diagrams, tables, figures, photographs) should be placed as closely as possible to the relevant text and ideally after it. They should be numbered consecutively and a reference to each should be included in the text: (see Table 5) at the end of a sentence or 'Figure 3 shows that...' etc. All illustrations, other than tables, are to be described as 'figures'.
- The SOURCE of all maps, tables etc must be given and an explanatory caption must be included.
- 1.5 line spacing should be used and the font size should be 12 point.
- REFERENCES should follow the 'Harvard' format as taught in course GEOG0151.

4.8 After submission

The criteria used to agree the mark for your work are included in the appendices to this handbook. All dissertations are fully independently second marked.

5. SUMMARY OF IMPORTANT DATES

- 1 **Wednesday 7 February 2024: submission of dissertation topic outline form**
- 2 **Wednesday 20 March 2024: submission of dissertation proposal**
- 3 Monday 20 May 2024: return of dissertation proposals
- 4 Tuesday 28–Wednesday 29 May 2024: first formal supervision and risk assessment
- 5 **Thursday 30 May 2024: submission of risk assessment and booking of laboratory space**
- 6 Wednesday 5 June 2024: re-submission of modified proposal/risk assessment and booking of laboratory space if original proposal was not approved
- 7 **Friday 4th October 2024: report on progress to supervisor via Moodle as a basis for final decision on registration for 45-credit or 30-credit dissertation (except 'Term Abroad' students)**
- 8 Monday 11 November 2024: short report on progress to supervisor via Moodle (4 Year International Programme students only)
- 9 **Thursday 5th December 2024: report on progress to supervisor via Moodle ('Term Abroad')**
- 10 Monday 13 January 2025: submission of new proposal from any IP student on year abroad wishing to request a change of dissertation topic (4 Year international Programme Students only)
- 11 Friday 14 February 2025: final date for submitting draft text to supervisor (except 'Term Abroad')
- 12 Wednesday 12 March 2025: final date for submitting draft text to supervisor ('Term Abroad')
- 13 **Monday 24 March 2025: SUBMISSION OF DISSERTATION (except 'Term Abroad')**
- 14 **Monday 28 April 2025: SUBMISSION OF DISSERTATION ('Term Abroad')**
- 15 Monday 19 May 2025: Submission of GEOG0068 Study Abroad Year Dissertation Report to supervisor via Moodle (4 Year International Programme students only)

APPENDIX A: GEOG0037 Marking Criteria (45 credits)

	Inadequate	Adequate	Fair	Good	Excellent	Outstanding	Exceptional
	1-19: 5 inadequate 1-5 20-29: 4 inadequate 1-5 30-39: 3 inadequate 1-5	40-49: Majority of 1-5 Adequate or higher	50-59: Majority 1-5 Fair or higher	60-69: Majority 1-5 Good or higher	70-79: Majority 1-5 Excellent or higher	80-89: Majority 1-5 Outstanding or higher	90+: Majority 1-5 Exceptional
1. Research aims and grasp of subject area	Very limited or no understanding of area. Muddled or derivative research aims.	Limited understanding of subject area. Confused or vague research aims.	Some understanding of subject area and reasonable research aims.	Sound understanding of subject area and focused, relevant research aims.	Deep understanding of subject area and originality in main research aims.	Impressive understanding of subject area and highly significant research aims.	Expert understanding of subject area; research aims suitable for a journal article.
2. Research methods	Very limited fieldwork or independent research. Little familiarity with methods or serious errors in application.	Limited fieldwork or independent research. Basic familiarity with methods, possibly with errors in application.	Evidence of fieldwork or independent research. Familiarity with application of appropriate methods.	Significant fieldwork or independent research. Clear familiarity with application of appropriate methods.	Substantial fieldwork or independent research. High ability in selection, application and discussion of methods.	Impressive fieldwork or independent research. Innovative selection, application and discussion of research methods.	Exceptional form of fieldwork or independent research paired with an expert-level discussion of research methods.
3. Reading	Very limited or irrelevant reading.	Significant omissions in reading with weak understanding of literature consulted.	Evidence of relevant reading and understanding of literature consulted.	Evidence of plentiful relevant reading and sound understanding of literature consulted.	Extensive reading and thorough understanding of literature consulted.	Impressive review and understanding of relevant literatures.	Expert-level review and innovative synthesis suitable for a journal.
4. Interpretation of evidence	Primarily descriptive analysis; limited, summary discussion of findings.	Limited critical analysis and subsequent discussion of implications.	Reasonable critical analysis and subsequent discussion of implications.	Sound critical analysis and meaningful discussion of implications.	Innovative critical analysis and originality in discussion of implications.	Impressive critical analysis and highly significant discussion of findings.	Critical analysis and subsequent discussion suitable for a journal.
5. Structure and development of argument	Confused, rambling or repetitive structure leading to incoherent argument.	Poor organisation seriously detracts from the development of argument.	Structure sometimes detracts from the development of argument.	Conventional structure with rare digressions occasionally marring the argument.	Logical, coherent structure that persuades of the author's argument.	Innovative structure that enhances development of the argument.	Highly original structure that adds substantially to development of the argument.
6. Writing and communication	Style, grammar and word choice seriously interfere with comprehension. (-3)	Style, grammar and word choice seriously detract from conveying ideas. (-2)	Style, grammar and word choice sometimes detract from conveying ideas. (-1)	Style, grammar and word choice rarely detract from conveying ideas. (0)	Style and word choice show fluency with ideas and flashes of verve. (1)	Style and word choice greatly enhance ideas and demonstrate verve. (2)	Reads as if professionally copy-edited. (3)
7. Presentation and references*	Poorly formatted or inappropriate visuals; very limited references. (-3)	Formatting, visuals and referencing seriously distract from argument(-2)	Formatting, visuals and referencing satisfactory. (-1)	Formatting, visuals and referencing rarely detract from argument (0)	Formatting, visuals and referencing are impeccable. (1)	Formatting, visuals and referencing actively contribute to argument. (2)	Exceptional presentation with impeccable format and references. (3)

* Elements of presentation vary but may include formatting (font consistency, headings, page numbers, bibliography), tables (clarity, labeling) and figures (quality, appropriateness).

APPENDIX B: GEOG0033 Marking Criteria (30 credits)

	Inadequate	Adequate	Fair	Good	Excellent	Outstanding	Exceptional
	1-19: 5 inadequate 1-5 20-29: 4 inadequate 1-5 30-39: 3 inadequate 1-5	40-49: Majority of 1-5 Adequate or higher	50-59: Majority 1-5 Fair or higher	60-69: Majority 1-5 Good or higher	70-79: Majority 1-5 Excellent or higher	80-89: Majority 1-5 Outstanding or higher	90+: Majority 1-5 Exceptional
1. Research aims and grasp of subject area	Very limited or no understanding of area. Muddled or derivative research aims.	Limited understanding of subject area. Confused or vague research aims.	Some understanding of subject area and reasonable research aims.	Sound understanding of subject area and focused, relevant research aims.	Deep understanding of subject area and originality in main research aims.	Impressive understanding of subject area and highly significant research aims.	Expert understanding of subject area; research aims suitable for a journal article.
2. Research approach	Very little or no sign of research being understood as a process of investigating specific research questions.	Basic acknowledgement of the need for research to investigate specific research questions.	Some evidence of the research being approached as a process of investigating specific research questions.	Clear evidence of the research being conducted as a process of investigating specific research questions.	Evidence of high ability in conducting research as a process of investigating specific research questions.	Impressive evidence of the research being conducted as a process of investigating specific research questions.	Exceptional form of fieldwork or independent research paired with an expert-level discussion of research methods.
3. Reading	Very limited or irrelevant reading.	Significant omissions in reading with weak understanding of literature consulted.	Evidence of relevant reading and understanding of literature consulted.	Evidence of plentiful relevant reading and sound understanding of literature consulted.	Extensive reading and thorough understanding of literature consulted.	Impressive review and understanding of relevant literatures.	Expert-level review and innovative synthesis suitable for a journal.
4. Interpretation of evidence	Primarily descriptive analysis; limited, summary discussion of findings.	Limited critical analysis and subsequent discussion of implications.	Reasonable critical analysis and subsequent discussion of implications.	Sound critical analysis and meaningful discussion of implications.	Innovative critical analysis and originality in discussion of implications.	Impressive critical analysis and highly significant discussion of findings.	Critical analysis and subsequent discussion suitable for a journal.
5. Structure and development of argument	Confused, rambling or repetitive structure leading to incoherent argument.	Poor organisation seriously detracts from the development of argument.	Structure sometimes detracts from the development of argument.	Conventional structure with rare digressions occasionally marring the argument.	Logical, coherent structure that persuades of the author's argument.	Innovative structure that enhances development of the argument.	Highly original structure that adds substantially to development of the argument.
6. Writing and communication	Style, grammar and word choice seriously interfere with comprehension. (-3)	Style, grammar and word choice seriously detract from conveying ideas. (-2)	Style, grammar and word choice sometimes detract from conveying ideas. (-1)	Style, grammar and word choice rarely detract from conveying ideas. (0)	Style and word choice show fluency with ideas and flashes of verve. (1)	Style and word choice greatly enhance ideas and demonstrate verve. (2)	Reads as if professionally copy-edited. (3)
7. Presentation and references*	Poorly formatted or inappropriate visuals; very limited references. (-3)	Formatting, visuals and referencing seriously distract from argument(-2)	Formatting, visuals and referencing satisfactory. (-1)	Formatting, visuals and referencing rarely detract from argument. (0)	Formatting, visuals and referencing are impeccable. (1)	Formatting, visuals and referencing actively contribute to argument. (2)	Exceptional presentation with impeccable format and references. (3)

* Elements of presentation vary but may include formatting (font consistency, headings, page numbers, bibliography), tables (clarity, labeling) and figures (quality, appropriateness).